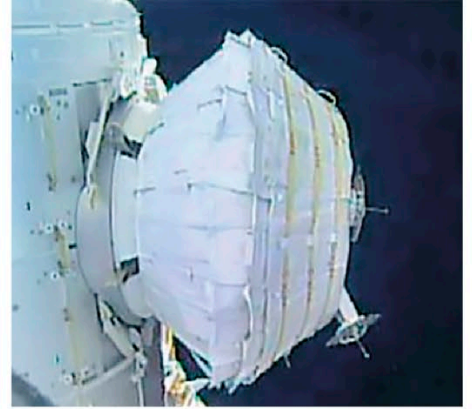
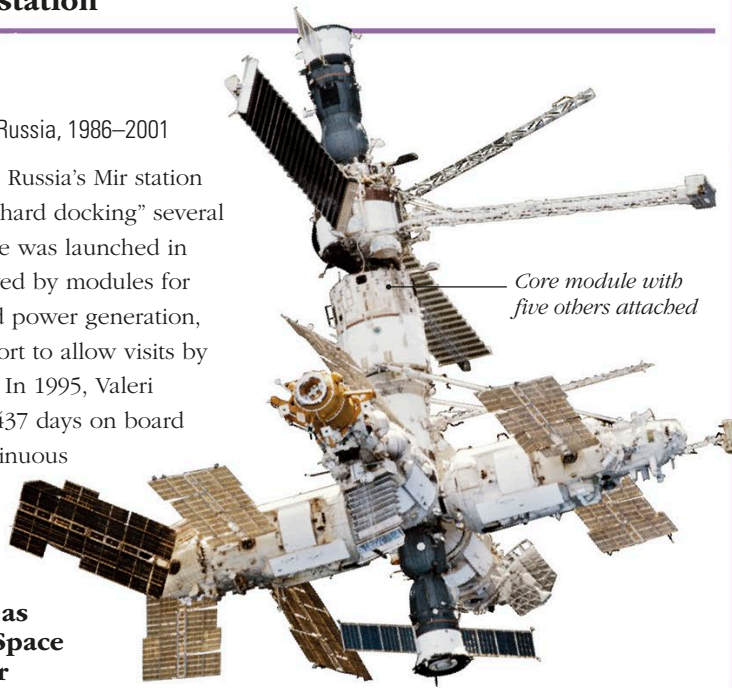


Modular space station

- **What?** Mir
- **Who?** Energia
- **Where and when?** Russia, 1986–2001

A significant advance, Russia's Mir station was built in orbit by "hard docking" several distinct units. The core was launched in February 1986, followed by modules for scientific research and power generation, and a new docking port to allow visits by NASA's Space Shuttle. In 1995, Valeri Polyakov completed 437 days on board Mir—the longest continuous stay in space.

Mir space station as viewed from the Space Shuttle Endeavour



Inflatable modules

- **What?** BEAM
- **Who?** Bigelow Aerospace
- **Where and when?** US, 2016

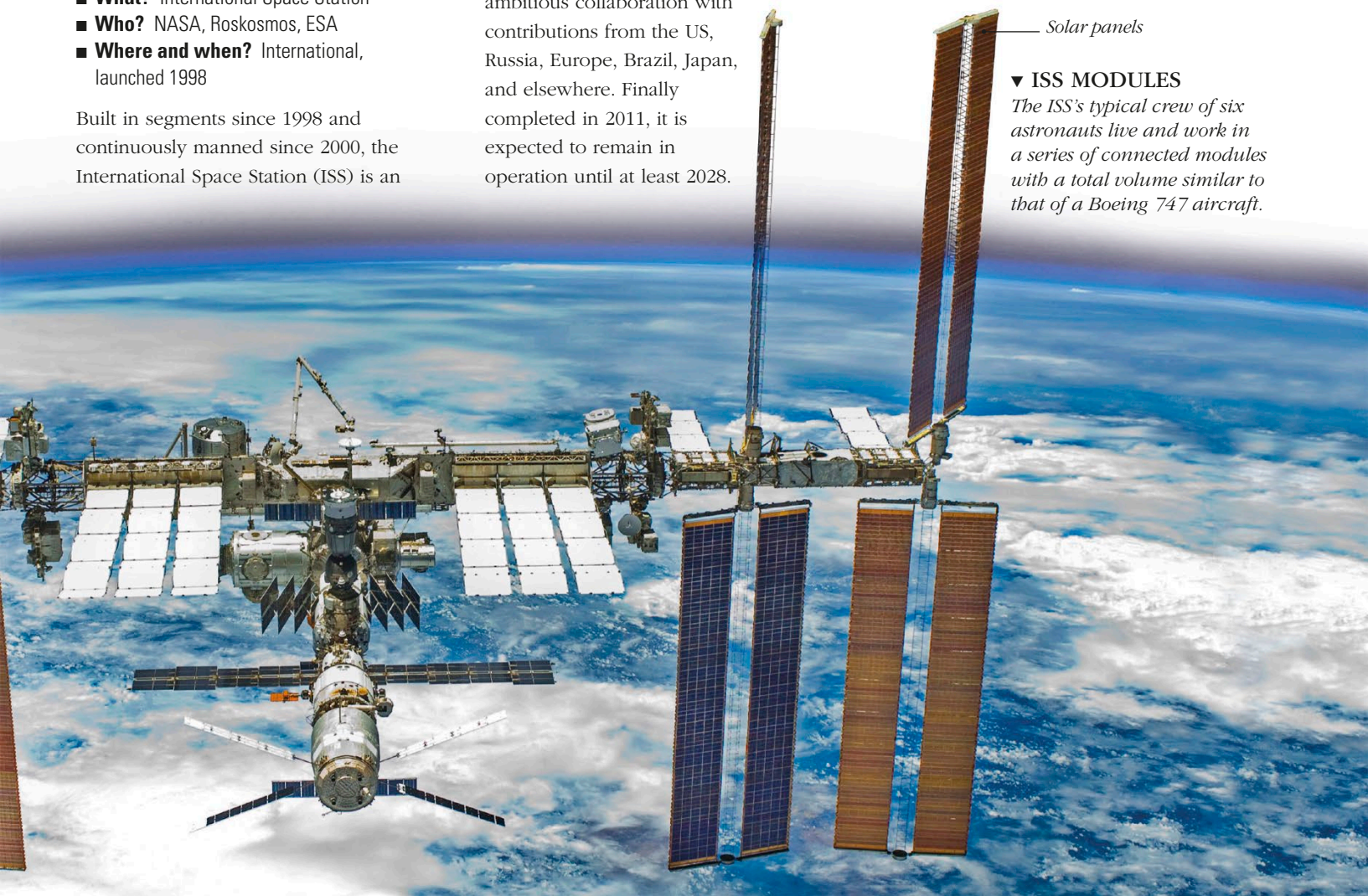
The Bigelow Expandable Activity Module (BEAM) is an inflatable, lightweight habitat that was attached to the ISS in 2016. It keeps its shape because of air pressure inside it. Experiments are being carried out to test conditions on board, and engineers hope BEAM could pave the way for other inflatable modules in the future.

The International Space Station

- **What?** International Space Station
- **Who?** NASA, Roskosmos, ESA
- **Where and when?** International, launched 1998

Built in segments since 1998 and continuously manned since 2000, the International Space Station (ISS) is an

ambitious collaboration with contributions from the US, Russia, Europe, Brazil, Japan, and elsewhere. Finally completed in 2011, it is expected to remain in operation until at least 2028.



▼ ISS MODULES

The ISS's typical crew of six astronauts live and work in a series of connected modules with a total volume similar to that of a Boeing 747 aircraft.